Claims & Returns Procedure

Document HPL-OPS-006 | Version 2.0 | Effective January 1, 2026 | Owner: Customer Operations

1. Purpose

This procedure explains how customers and HPL staff report loss, damage and shortages, how freight claims are filed and resolved, and how customer returns are authorized and processed.

2. Reporting Damage and Shortages at Delivery

2.1 **Visible damage.** Damage or shortage that is visible at delivery must be noted on the delivery receipt / BOL at time of delivery. Describe the damage specifically (for example "2 cartons crushed, contents exposed") - a note such as "subject to inspection" is not sufficient.

2.2 **Concealed damage.** Damage discovered after delivery, when packaging showed no outside damage, must be reported to claims@harborpine.example within 5 business days of delivery. Keep all packaging and the damaged goods for inspection.

2.3 **Photos.** Take photos of the packaging, the labels and the damaged goods before moving or discarding anything.

3. Filing a Claim

3.1 **Deadline.** A written claim must be filed within 9 months of the delivery date, or of the scheduled delivery date for freight that was never delivered.

3.2 **Required documents.**

- Claim form with the HPL shipment ID (SH-NNNNN) and claimed amount
- Copy of the BOL and the signed delivery receipt showing the exception
- Commercial invoice or other proof of the value of the goods
- Photos (Section 2.3) and, for concealed damage, the inspection report
- Repair estimate, if the goods can be repaired

3.3 **Amount.** The claim amount is the invoice value of the lost or damaged goods, subject to the liability limit in Section 4.

4. Liability Limits

4.1 Carrier liability is limited to $2.50 per pound of lost or damaged freight unless a higher value was declared on the BOL and accepted by the carrier before shipment (HPL-LEG-001, Section 8.2).

4.2 **Example.** A 400 lb pallet of goods invoiced at $3,000 is destroyed. Without declared value, the maximum recovery is 400 lb x $2.50 = $1,000.00.

4.3 HPL is not liable for delays caused by force majeure events (see HPL-COM-003, Section 5.1) or for loss of profit or other indirect damages.

5. Claim Handling

5.1 HPL acknowledges every claim within 3 business days of receipt.

5.2 HPL aims to resolve claims within 30 days of receiving a complete claim package. Complex claims involving inspection or salvage may take longer; the customer is updated at least every 15 days.

5.3 When a shipment has a reported damage exception, the shipment record is marked as an exception and the claim reference is added to it.

5.4 Approved claims are paid by credit to the customer's next invoice or by bank transfer, at the customer's choice.

6. Customer Returns

6.1 **Authorization.** A Return Merchandise Authorization (RMA) number is required for every return. Requests go to ops@harborpine.example. Freight arriving without an RMA number is refused.

6.2 **Return window.** Returns must be requested within 30 days of the original delivery date.

6.3 **Restocking fee.** Undamaged returns that are not caused by an HPL error are subject to a restocking fee of 15% of the goods' value. No restocking fee applies when HPL shipped the wrong item or the goods were damaged in transit.

6.4 **Hazmat returns.** Hazardous materials, including lithium batteries, may only be returned to a facility with hazmat docks and with a hazmat-certified carrier, following HPL-EHS-004. Damaged lithium batteries cannot be returned through HPL.

6.5 **Inspection.** Returned goods are inspected within 2 business days of receipt and either restocked, held for the customer's decision, or disposed of on the customer's written instruction.